

8.2 File Compression

Files on a hard drive are stored as a sequence of ones and zeroes, and often contain repeated patterns. A file compression program takes advantage of these patterns to reduce the file size. By assigning codes to particular repeated patterns, the compression program converts a large file into a smaller one, which contains a 'brief description' of the original file. Typically, a space saving of 10 to 30 per cent can be achieved for standard files.

Hard drives are getting cheaper, and drive space is no longer that much of an issue - so compression utilities have lost the advantage they once offered. However, you need to have at least one installed on your system, since file compression is still used when transmitting large files over the Internet, and in archiving.

We looked at three free applications that offer almost all the features found in paid utilities.

8.2.1 ZipGenius 6.0.2.103

ZipGenius works out as a great alternative to the venerable WinZip that everybody is so accustomed to. The small 4.5 MB installer packs in good number of features for a free utility.

On installation, ZipGenius integrates with the file manager so it can associate with the compressed files on your system. It supports around 23 formats, which include esoteric formats such as 7z, and Czip (crypto zip), as well as RAR, TAR, Z, etc. By default, ZipGenius associates with only a few compressed file types - you need to select other formats manually for association.

When launched from the 'Programs' menu, the application presents a wizard-type menu. You can shift to the 'expert' menu if you're sure about your skills.

Apart from standard features such as file compression, self-extracting archives, spanning, etc., ZipGenius also has a backup option. Here, you can take backups of your My Documents, My